

RUMORS OF BREAD IN THE HOUSE OF BREAD

TEXT: *Ruth 1:1-6* “Now it came to pass in the days when the judges ruled, that there was a famine in the land And a certain man of Bethlehem Judah went to sojourn in the country of Moab, he, and his wife, and his two sons.² And the name of the man was Elimelech, and the name of his wife Naomi, and the name of his two sons Mahlon and Chilion, Ephrathites of Bethlehemjudah. And they came into the country of Moab, and continued there.³ And Elimelech Naomi's husband died; and she was left, and her two sons.⁴ And they took them wives of the women of Moab; the name of the one was Orpah, and the name of the other Ruth: and they dwelled there about ten years.⁵ And Mahlon and Chilion died also both of them; and the woman was left of her two sons and her husband.⁶ Then she arose with her daughters in law, that she might return from the country of Moab: for she had heard in the country of Moab how that the Lord had visited his people in giving them bread.”

INTRO: The Book of Ruth is a relatively small book, covering only four chapters and 85 verses. This book is somewhat unique in that it is difficult to preach from without preaching the entire book. So today I would like to preach all four chapters and 85 verses! (Just kidding!)

The Book of Ruth was written during the time of the Judges. The author is unknown but believed to be Samuel. The main thrust of the whole book is to show how a Gentile woman became an ancestor of Christ.

As I preach today I would like for you to keep several things in mind;

Bethlehem Judah represents the Church.

Moab represents the world.

Elimelech, Naomi, Mahlon and Chilion represent the backslider.

Ruth and Orpah represent the unchurched.

The **“Bread”** represents the presence of God.

Boaz represents Jesus.

I. THE CONSEQUENCES OF A FAMINE IN THE CHURCH!

A. Bethlehem Judah had probably been home to Elimelech, Naomi and their son’s for most, if not all of their lives. The reason I believe Bethlehem Judah represents the Church is that it’s very name means ***“the house of bread”***!

Historically **“Bread”** has always been the one thing that was an indicator of the presence of God. In Old Testament worship **“bread”** occupied a very important place in the form of the **“showbread”**. This **“showbread”** was called ***“the bread of the Presence”***.

“Showbread” might better be interpreted as ***“show up bread,”*** or in the Hebraic terms, ***“face bread”***. By ***“face bread”*** we mean that God’s face is visible to his people. **“Showbread”** was a heavenly symbol of God Himself.

In your Bible when you see the word **“Bread”** it will in some way be connected to the presence of God! Jesus is said to be that **“Bread”** that has come down from Heaven.

B. Elimelech, Naomi and their family have no doubt developed lifelong relationships, and probably never had a thought of living anywhere other than Bethlehem! Yet, the Word of God tells us that this family of four pulled up stakes and moved to Moab!

This is no small decision. When you pull up stakes and move your family, everything about your life changes! (Residence, schools, jobs, worship places, doctors, grocery stores, filling stations.... everything!) (Susan’s comments with regard to Pastoral elections - For those of you that love that kind of thing so much, let me ask you, how would you like to have everyone in your company cast a vote on you every year or two, and the consequences of not receiving a strong vote means that not only do you no longer have a job, but your family must move out of town and totally relocate?)

According to this Scripture, the reason Elimelech, Naomi, and their family moved to Moab is because ***“there was a famine in the land.”***

In other words, the land that had been known for raising the necessary ingredients for making and manufacturing **“bread”** can no longer sustain it’s residents because it has become barren!

C. How many people do you know, who at one time feasted at the table of God, ate **“Bread”** at the Lord’s table, and for whatever

reason they have moved to Moab? They have gone back into the world? (Not everyone who has gone back into the world is absent from church today!)

In essence Elimelech, Naomi and their two sons backslid and moved to Moab! Friends that is absolutely tragic! What's more tragic than that is why it happened, there was ***“no bread in the house of bread”!***

Naomi and her family have something in common with the people who leave or totally avoid our churches today, they left in search of ***“bread”***.

I can tell you why people are flocking to the bars, the clubs, the psychics and the mediums, they're trying to find something to satisfy the empty feeling created by a famine in the Church!

There is no doubt, the Church has failed the past couple of generations of people! Look around, and you will discover that the families of those who founded the Pentecostal Church in America are strangely absent from it's ranks.

There was a time when a person reached their late teens and early twenties they dropped out of Church, never to return. How could this happen?

We have had a famine there has been ***“no bread in the house of bread”!*** They looked to us and all they found was offices full of recipes for ***“bread”***, cold ovens, and dusty bare shelves! Sure, we've always made sure we had a sign in the front yard of the Church, advertising the fact that we were in the process of baking

“bread”. The signs read like this:
First Assembly of God Church!

First Church of God Church!

First Pentecostal Church!

Word of Faith Church!

Church on The Rock!

Four Square Church of God!

First Pentecostal Holiness Church!

The modern day Pentecostal/Charismatic Church has falsely advertised and hyped-up our claims that there is **“bread”** in our house.

The very best most Churches have to offer to those who wander through their doors in search of **“bread”** is to give them permission to search through the carpet for a few crumbs of yester-year's revivals.

It reminds me of the veil in the Most Holy Place hiding the fact that the Ark Of The Covenant was missing, while the ignorant multitudes worshipped just a few short feet away totally oblivious to the fact that the Glory of God was absent!

I wonder, do we even know whether He is here or not? If He is here, what is He doing? Where is He going?

Is it possible that we have become so preoccupied with sweeping out imaginary crumbs from bakeries with no ***“bread”*** that we are not even aware that we are in the midst of a famine?

Sure, people are leaving Churches by the dozens, can you blame them? There is ***“no bread in the house of bread”!***

I realize there are many reasons that people leave churches, and when people leave it is not always the Pastor, or the Church’s fault! Sometimes people want their own way, and if they don’t get it they leave!

I am convinced however, that when people leave through backsliding it is more times than not because there is ***“no bread in the house of bread”!***

People have come to the ***“house of bread”*** time and again only to find there was simply too much of man and too little of God there.

God wants to restore the sense of His awesome manifest presence in our lives and places of worship. Over and over we talk about the glory of God covering the earth, but how is His Glory going to flow through the streets of our cities if it can't even flow down the aisles of our Churches?

If we are going to have ***“bread in the house of bread”*** it's got to start somewhere, and it's not going to start out there. It must start in here! For the presence of God to be rediscovered in the Church three things must happen:

Someone must pay the price to have ***“bread in the house of bread”!***

We must be willing to lay aside our agenda, and become willing to abide by His agenda, and His alone!

We must be willing to be a consumer and distributor of the ***“bread”!***
We must be hungry!

Where will ***“bread”*** begin to be rediscovered in our world? Ezekiel wrote: ***“...I saw water coming out from under the threshold of the temple...”*** (Ezek. 47:1 NIV).

Are we going to allow a famine to continue to rob us of the ability to raise the necessary ingredients to manufacture ***“bread”***? Are we going to be satisfied to talk about ***“bread”***, and distribute our product as if it has been rationed?

Or are we going to rise up by faith with bulldog determination and build a bakery that manufactures ***“bread”*** at 1421 South Main Street, in Malvern Arkansas?

II. THE HIGH COST OF BACKSLIDING!

A. The priority of God's presence has been lost in the modern Church. We're like bakeries that are open, but have no ***“bread”***.

Quite frankly I'm not sure that some of our Churches would be interested in trafficking in ***“bread”*** if they could! They are more concerned with being seeker sensitive, than developing a sensitivity to the Holy Spirit!

I'm afraid we have come to the place where we just like the chit-chat that goes on around cold ovens and empty shelves. That kind of activity centers around what used to be. In conversations such as that you will frequently hear phrases like:
I remember when...

Back in the 50's, 60's, 70's, 80's....

In the good old day's....

When there is no ***“bread in the house of bread”*** backsliding will accelerate! People will walk away disillusioned, many of them will never return! Are we willing to take that risk?

B. Elimelech, Naomi and their boy's didn't just wake up one morning and decide to throw all their belongings in the back of a wagon and move from Bethlehem to Moab!

They probably sat around and discussed their options! (The power of life and death is in the tongue!)

The Israelites were guilty of this very thing. Following their deliverance from Egyptian bondage God miraculously provided for them manna from Heaven, but it wasn't very long until they were desiring Egypt's diet again! **Numbers 11:5-6** ***“We remember the fish, which we did eat in Egypt freely; the cucumbers, and the melons, and the leeks, and the onions, and the garlick: ‘But now our soul is dried away: there is nothing at all, beside this manna, before our eyes.’”***

C. The story of Elimelech, Naomi and their boy's is not much different than that of those who have left the modern day Church in

a backslidden condition. Let's look at it:

Backsliding is a process! It's the little foxes that spoil the vine!

Backsliding is simplified by the lack of ***“bread in the house of bread”!***

Elimelech, Naomi and their son's lived in a backslidden condition for ten years! How many parents have backslid when their children were at a very impressionable age, while have returned to God, their children have not come with them? It's time for parents to stand up and say WITH Joshua of old, ***“as for me and my house we WILL serve the Lord”!***

Elimelech, Naomi and their two son's left Bethlehem and only one of them ever returned! That's the story of backsliding - there will always be casualties! Elimelech, Mahlon and Chilion never came home, they died in Moab!

Remember, when you backslide, for whatever reason, it will always take you farther than you intended to go, keep you longer than you intended to stay, and cost far more than you intended to pay! Notice the words of Naomi to the residents of Bethlehem when she returned home, **Ruth 1:21 “I went out full, and the Lord hath brought me home again empty: why then call ye me Naomi, seeing the Lord hath testified against me, and the Almighty hath afflicted me?”**

The road that the backslider travels, is a fight against God!

There always have been, and always will be, a high cost to pay for backsliding!

Mark this down, when you leave ***“The house of bread”*** and move

your belongings to Moab you will no longer have a touch of God on your life! The loss of his presence is the highest possible price to pay for backsliding! (When David's sin was discovered, one of the first things he said was, ***"take not your Holy Spirit from me"!***)

III. RUMORS OF BREAD REACH MOAB!

A. Naomi discovered:

Moab was a cruel place. The Word of God says, ***"The way of a transgressor is hard"!***

Moab will steal your children from you and bury them before their time.

Moab will separate you from your spouse.

Moab will rob the very vitality of life from you.

In the final analysis, all that Naomi had left were two daughters-in-law whom she had known only ten years or less. With nothing but a gloomy and disastrous future staring her in the face, she told them, ***"You might as well not hang around me either. I don't have any more sons to give you."***

B. Some of the most heartening words in this Book are found in **Ruth 1:6** **"...*she had heard in the country of Moab how that the Lord had visited his people in giving them bread*"**

There is an information ***"grapevine"*** that winds its way through every community, hamlet, and city of the world. It winds its way down all our coasts, over every mountain range, and into every place where men and women dwell.

It is the *"grapevine of the hungry."* When the backslider hears the *"rumor"* that *"bread is back in the house of bread"*, the news will flow like a surge of electricity through a power line at near the speed of light.

The news of *"bread"* will leapfrog from one household to the other, from one place to another almost instantaneously. You won't have to worry about advertising on TV or promoting the Church in the usual ways of the world. The hungry will just hear. The news will break, and people will start coming out of the woodwork! The backsliders will come back to the Church en masse!

All you have to do to build a Church is get the *"bread back in the house of bread"*!

C. When Naomi returned home to Bethlehem, she brought Ruth with her. Naomi tried to get Ruth to stay in Moab. Notice the words of Ruth, **Ruth 1:16-17** *"And Ruth said, Intreat me not to leave thee, or to return from following after thee: for whither thou goest, I will go; and where thou lodgest, I will lodge: thy people shall be my people, and thy God my God: ¹⁷Where thou diest, will I die, and there will I be buried: the Lord do so to me, and more also, if ought but death part thee and me."*

Remember I told you that Ruth represents the unchurched. When backsliders return and discover *"bread in the house of bread"* they will always bring with them the unchurched!

IV. RUMORS OF BREAD BECOME REALITY!

A. When Naomi and Ruth come to Bethlehem, Ruth goes job hunting. **Ruth 2:3** *"So she went out and began to glean in the fields behind the harvesters. As it turned out, she found herself working in a field belonging to Boaz, who*

was from the clan of Elimelech.”

Remember, Boaz the kinsman redeemer, represents Jesus! I want you to know that the Lord of the Church has a place in **“the house of bread”** for every heathen and backslider! In fact the scripture say’s that He is married to the backslider!

B. Notice the actions of Boaz:

He notices her! **Ruth 2:5-6** ***“Boaz asked the foreman of his harvesters, “Whose young woman is that?” “The foreman replied, “She is the Moabitess who came back from Moab with Naomi.”*** Jesus has noticed us! ***“We did not choose him, he chose us!”***

He makes a place for her! **Ruth 2:8** ***“So Boaz said to Ruth, “My daughter, listen to me. Don't go and glean in another field and don't go away from here. Stay here with my servant girls.”*** Jesus has made a place for us! ***“We have been grafted into the true vine!”***

He offers her his protection! **Ruth 2:9** ***“Watch the field where the men are harvesting, and follow along after the girls. I have told the men not to touch you And whenever you are thirsty, go and get a drink from the water jars the men have filled.”*** Jesus offers us His protection! ***“He has given his Angels charge concerning us!” “No plague shall come nigh your dwelling!”***

He romances her! **Ruth 2:14** ***“At mealtime Boaz said to her, “Come over here. Have some bread and dip it in the wine vinegar.”***
When she sat down with the harvesters, he offered her some roasted grain. She ate all she wanted and had some left over.”
God has sent the Holy Spirit to prepare a bride for his Son! We are the ***“apple of his eye”!***

He provides for her! **Ruth 2:15-18** *"As she got up to glean, Boaz gave orders to his men, "Even if she gathers among the sheaves, don't embarrass her. ¹⁶Rather, pull out some stalks for her from the bundles and leave them for her to pick up on purpose, and don't rebuke her." ¹⁷So Ruth gleaned in the field until evening. Then she threshed the barley she had gathered, and it amounted to about a bushel and three pints. ¹⁸She carried it back to town, and her mother-in-law saw how much she had gathered. Ruth also brought out and gave her what she had left over after she had eaten enough."*

"But my God shall supply all your need, according to his riches in Glory by Christ Jesus!"

He falls in love with her! **Ruth 3:7-11** *"When Boaz had finished eating and drinking and was in good spirits, he went over to lie down at the far end of the grain pile. Ruth approached quietly, uncovered his feet and lay down. ⁸In the middle of the night something startled the man, and he turned and discovered a woman lying at his feet. ⁹"Who are you?" he asked. "I am your servant Ruth," she said. "Spread the corner of your garment over me, since you are a kinsman-redeemer." ¹⁰"The Lord bless you, my daughter," he replied. "This kindness is greater than that which you showed earlier: You have not run after the younger men, whether rich or poor. ¹¹And now, my daughter, don't be afraid. I will do for you all you ask. All my fellow townsmen know that you are a woman of noble character." He loved us enough to go to the cross for us! Paul said, *"Husbands love your wives, as Christ loved the Church, and gave himself for it!"**

Because of the death of Elimelech, there was another relative who had a right to Naomi's estate. When a person backslides the right to their persons and possessions, is transferred to another master, the devil!

Boaz performed the duties necessary to have the right to Naomi's property, and to marry Ruth! He went to the elders of Bethlehem and brought the near kinsman before them. Of course the near kinsman did not possess the wherewithal to purchase the possession. In so doing the near kinsman who had the first right of redemption pulled off his shoe and gave it to his neighbor, thus passing his right to the property and people in question to Boaz!

Friends that is precisely what Jesus did for us at the cross 2,000 years ago!

He marries her! **Ruth 4:13** ***"So Boaz took Ruth and she became his wife.."*** The greatest wedding of all times will occur at the rapture. There will be such fanfare over that wedding that it will take seven years to have the reception!

Because of Ruth's marriage to Boaz she conceives children, Naomi becomes a grandmother, and Ruth becomes an ancestor of David, and of Jesus Christ! **Ruth 4:13-17** ***"So Boaz took Ruth and she became his wife. Then he went to her, and the Lord enabled her to conceive, and she gave birth to a son."*** ¹⁴***The women said to Naomi: "Praise be to the Lord, who this day has not left you without a kinsman-redeemer. May he become famous throughout Israel!"*** ¹⁵***He will renew your life and sustain you in your old age. For your daughter-in-law, who loves you and who is better to you than seven sons, has given him birth."*** ¹⁶***Then Naomi took the child, laid him in her lap and cared for him.*** ¹⁷***The women living there said, "Naomi has a son." And they named him Obed. He was the father of Jesse, the father of David."*** When the heathen marries up with Jesus, and the backslider renews

her vows, sons and daughters are born into the Kingdom of God!

Because of her marriage to Boaz, Ruth and Naomi would never have to worry about having enough **“bread”** again!

As long as we stay married to the Lord of the Church, there will always be **“bread in the house of bread”!**

C. I am thoroughly convinced that God is doing everything in his power to place **“bread”** back into **“the house of bread”**.

Will you help bake some heavenly **“bread”** to be distributed in a world that is experiencing a very costly and devastating famine?

THE END!

RUMORS OF BREAD IN THE HOUSE OF BREAD

TEXT: **Ruth 1:1-6** *“Now it came to pass in the days when the judges ruled, that there was a famine in the land And a certain man of Bethlehem Judah went to sojourn in the country of Moab, he, and his wife, and his two sons. ²And the name of the man was Elimelech, and the name of his wife Naomi, and the name of his two sons Mahlon and Chilion, Ephrathites of Bethlehemjudah. And they came into the country of Moab, and continued there. ³And Elimelech Naomi's husband died; and she was left, and her two sons. ⁴And they took them wives of the women of Moab; the name of the one was Orpah, and the name of the other Ruth: and they dwelled there about ten years. ⁵And Mahlon and Chilion died also both of them; and the woman was left of her two sons and her husband. ⁶Then she arose with her daughters in law, that she might return from the country of Moab: for she had heard in the country of Moab how that the Lord had visited his people in giving them bread.””*

Things to keep in mind;

Bethlehem Judah represents the Church.

Moab represents the world.

Elimelech, Naomi, Mahlon and Chilion represent the backslider.

Ruth and Orpah represent the unchurched.

The **“Bread”** represents the presence of God.

Boaz represents Jesus

I. THE CONSEQUENCES OF A FAMINE IN THE CHURCH!

Historically **“Bread”** has always been an indicator of the presence of God.

According to this Scripture, the reason Elimelech, Naomi, and their family moved to Moab is because ***“there was a famine in the land.”***

Naomi and her family have something in common with the people who leave or totally avoid our churches today, they left in search of ***“bread”***.

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The very best most Churches have to offer to those who wander through their doors in search of ***“bread”*** is to give them permission to search through the carpet for a few crumbs of yester-year's

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